Ducks on the Millpond

Old Time • Key of D • G Diatonic Harmonica • 2nd Position • AAABB Form

Source: Grayson County, Virginia • Recorded by Alan Lomax from Emmett Lundy (1941)

Watch Part 1 — Intro & A Part Low Octave

Watch Part 2 — B Part Low Octave

Watch Part 3 — A Part Mid/High Octave

Watch Part 4 — B Part & Mixing Octaves

Watch Part 5 — 1st Position Version

Notation: " = whole tone bend tuh/tu huh = tongue articulation / = octave split

Reference Scale — Major Pentatonic, 2nd Position:

```
(-1 +2) -2 -"3 -3 +4 -4 +5 +6 -6 -7 +8 +9
```

A Part — Play Three Times (Low Octave)

Basic Melody

```
+3  +tuh huh
-4 -3" +3  +tuh +3
+4 -4 -3" +3  +tuh +3
+4 -4 -3" +3  +tuh
+2 -1 +2 +3  -3" +3 +2  +tuh +3
```

B Part — Play Twice (Low Octave)

Basic Melody

```
+4 -3 -3" +3  +tuh +3
+4 -3 -3" -4 -3 -3" +3
+4 -3 -3" +3  +tuh +3
+2 -1 +2 +3  -3" +3 +2  +tuh +3
```

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Mid/High Octave — Octave Splits

Watch Part 3 — A Part Mid/High Octave

Watch Part 4 — B Part & Mixing Octaves

A Part — Play Three Times (Mid/High Octave)

Octave Split Version

```
+3/6  +tu huh
-4/7 -6 +3/6  +tuh +3/6
+4/7 -4/7 -6 +3/6  +tuh +3/6
+4/7 -4/7 -6 +3/6  +tuh
+2/5 -1/4 +2/5 +3/6  -56 +3/6 +2/5  +tuh +3/6
```

B Part — Play Twice (Mid/High Octave)

Octave Split Version

```
+4/7 -7 -6 +3/6  +tuh +3/6
+4/7 -7 -6 -4/7 -7 -6 +3/6
+4/7 -7 -6 +3/6  +tuh +3/6
+2/5 -1/4 +2/5 +3/6  -56 +3/6 +2/5  +tuh +3/6
```

Taking It Further

- Start with single notes in the low octave, then graduate to octave splits
- Use the fox chase tongue rhythm underneath for drive and groove
- Move between low and mid/high octaves within the same pass for variety
- Try the 1st position version (D harp) to cut through in larger jams
- Work on dynamics — quiet on the A parts, push on the B part climbs
- Listen to the Pine Tree String Band version for feel and phrasing

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Ducks on the Millpond

Watch Part 1 — Intro & A Part Low Octave

Watch Part 5 — 1st Position Version

Origins

The earliest known recording of Ducks on the Millpond comes from fiddler Emmett Lundy (1864–1953) of Grayson County, Virginia, captured by Alan Lomax in 1941. Lundy reportedly learned most of his tunes from local fiddler Greenbury Leonard, a musician whom others called "the best there ever was." Where Leonard picked up the tune — if he is indeed Lundy's source — is unknown, but it likely circulated among the fiddle and banjo players of the Virginia–North Carolina border region for generations before anyone thought to record it.

The tune is a staple of Appalachian and Southern string band traditions, particularly associated with the Round Peak style of Surry County, North Carolina and southwestern Virginia. Over time it was further popularised by fiddlers like Tommy Jarrell and bands like The Camp Creek Boys, featuring the great clawhammer banjo player Kyle Creed. Today it sits firmly in the old-time canon as a jam session favourite at festivals, contests, and front porch gatherings.

Key Recordings

Emmett Lundy's 1941 recording for Alan Lomax is the touchstone — most versions of the tune trace back to it, and it showcases the raw, unpolished Virginia fiddling style that defined the tradition. Tommy Jarrell's version cemented the tune as a Round Peak classic, while Kyle Creed and The Camp Creek Boys brought it to a wider old-time audience with their lively band arrangements.

More recently, the tune appears on the Country Mountain Banjo album by the Pine Tree String Band, whose mellow fretless banjo sound inspired this harmonica arrangement. Contemporary players like Rayna Gellert and the duo of George Jackson and Tristan Scroggins have also recorded fine versions that keep the traditional feel alive while adding their own character.

Playing This Tune

This version is played in second position on a G diatonic harmonica in the key of D. The low octave version sits around holes 1–4, using tongue articulations (tuh, tu huh) to drive the rhythm forward. The mid/high octave version moves up to holes 3–9 using octave splits — playing two holes three apart simultaneously (e.g. +3/6, -4/7) — for a fuller, more powerful sound.

The tune follows an AAABB form: the A part played three times, the B part twice. Start with the low octave single notes to get the melody and rhythm locked in, then move up to the octave split version. Once both are comfortable, try mixing between the two within the same pass through the tune. There's also a 1st position version on D harmonica that cuts through better in larger jam settings — worth exploring once the 2nd position version is solid.

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